

Allergies

The immune system protects the body by attacking foreign materials such as germs. In some people, however, it can misfire and attack harmless foreign substances. We call this overreaction an allergy. Allergies range from mild conditions, such as the runny nose of hay fever, to a life-threatening reaction called anaphylaxis.

TRIGGERS

Things that trigger allergies are known as allergens. Common allergens include nuts, pollen (a powder made by flowers), and animal hairs. Allergens can cause a reaction if they are swallowed, breathed in, or even touched. The affected part of the body often becomes red and swollen as though infected by germs.

WOW!

Allergic reactions can be triggered by exercise, perfume, chocolate, gold, household dust, cell phones, and even water.

► **POLLEN GRAINS** Released by flowers, pollen grains can cause allergies such as hay fever.

HOW ALLERGIES WORK

Allergens work by activating certain types of white blood cells that normally respond only to germs. Allergen molecules bind to chemicals called antibodies on the surface of the white blood cells. In response, the white blood cells burst and release a chemical called histamine, which causes body tissues nearby to swell up and become sore.

